

CHIVE ARCADE // FREE CHECKLIST

7 Game Ideas You Can Actually Finish in a Weekend

Small enough to finish. Good enough to publish.

Pick one Friday night. Ship it Sunday night.

From the studio that ships a browser game every week.

No theory. Just seven scoped ideas, each with its
one mechanic, its build list, and its cut list.

chivearcade.com

chivearcade.com - Ship a game every week.

Read this first: the idea filter

Most beginner games die from the same cause: too much game. Every idea in this checklist passed a filter before it made the list:

- ☐ ONE mechanic. If you cannot describe the fun in one verb (catch, dodge, time, fling), cut verbs until you can.
- ☐ ONE screen of play. No levels, no world map, no progression tree. Difficulty comes from speed and density, not content.
- ☐ PHONE-FIRST. If it does not play with one thumb, it does not ship.
- ☐ SUNDAY-NIGHT TEST. Could a stranger open it, understand it in ten seconds, and lose happily? If not, shrink it.

How to use this checklist

Friday night: pick ONE idea. Saturday: build the loop. Sunday morning: polish what confuses players. Sunday night: publish on itch.io and post the launch. Each idea page gives you the loop, the build list, the cut list, and three tuning numbers. Check boxes as you go.

IDEA 01 OF 07

DROP CATCHER

Things fall. You catch the good ones and dodge the bad ones.

THE LOOP

Move a basket left and right. Catch falling coins, dodge falling anvils. Miss three coins or catch one anvil and the run ends.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: MOVE. Left/right (arrow keys or drag) is the entire control scheme.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Basket that follows input smoothly
- ☐ Two falling object types: good and bad
- ☐ Score + best score saved locally
- ☐ Three-strikes fail state and game-over screen
- ☐ Catch sound and fail sound (generated, no audio files)

CUT THIS

- x Power-ups and combos
- x Multiple levels or backgrounds
- x Character selection
- x Story or tutorial text

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Fall speed: start 220 px/s, +12 per 10 points
- Spawn interval: start 1.1s, shrink to 0.45s
- Bad-item ratio: start 15%, cap at 35%

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: A stranger can play for 60 seconds without asking how it works.

IDEA 02 OF 07

PERFECT TIMING

One button. Press it at exactly the right instant.

THE LOOP

A needle sweeps around a dial (or a bar fills and drains). Tap when it is inside the green zone. Each hit shrinks the zone and speeds the needle. One miss ends the run.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: TAP. A single input, keyboard or touch, is the whole game.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Sweeping needle with a visible target zone
- ☐ Zone shrinks + speed rises after every hit
- ☐ Score = consecutive perfect hits, best saved
- ☐ Instant restart on miss (no menus between runs)
- ☐ Hit tick and fail buzz for feedback

CUT THIS

- ☒ Multiple game modes
- ☒ Unlockable dials or skins
- ☒ Online leaderboards
- ☒ Animated cutscenes

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Start zone width: 24 degrees, shrink 1.5 per hit
- Needle speed: start 140 deg/s, +8 per hit
- Perfect window: center third of the zone scores double

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: Losing feels like YOUR fault, and restarting takes under one second.

IDEA 03 OF 07

DODGE RUN

You cannot stop moving. The gaps are the game.

THE LOOP

Your ship auto-scrolls upward through falling walls with gaps. Steer left and right through the gaps. Speed rises the longer you survive. One collision ends the run.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: STEER. Continuous left/right movement, no brakes.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Auto-scrolling playfield with wall-and-gap obstacles
- ☐ Smooth steering with a little drift (feels fast)
- ☐ Distance score + best distance
- ☐ Collision ends the run instantly
- ☐ Near-miss whoosh when you thread a tight gap

CUT THIS

- ✗ Weapons or shooting
- ✗ Pickups and currency
- ✗ Boss encounters
- ✗ Multiple ships

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Scroll speed: start 260 px/s, +15 every 5 seconds
- Gap width: start 34% of screen, shrink to 22%
- Steer accel: snappy enough to cross the screen in 0.6s

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: Surviving 45 seconds feels earned, and every death teaches the next run.

IDEA 04 OF 07

BRICK BREAKER REMIX

Breakout, but with exactly one twist that changes everything.

THE LOOP

Bounce a ball with your paddle to smash bricks. The twist: pick ONE (gravity flips every 20 seconds, the paddle shrinks as you score, or two balls spawn at 50% bricks cleared). Clear the wall to win.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: BOUNCE. Paddle left/right; the twist is the only surprise.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Paddle, ball physics, destructible brick wall
- ☐ Your ONE twist, tuned to matter by mid-game
- ☐ Score per brick + win screen when the wall clears
- ☐ Lose-a-ball / three-balls fail state
- ☐ Brick-break pop sounds with rising pitch

CUT THIS

- ✗ More than one twist (pick one and commit)
- ✗ Ten level layouts (ship three, max)
- ✗ Paddle power-ups
- ✗ Story framing

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Ball speed: start 320 px/s, +6% per 10 bricks
- Twist trigger point: around 40-60% through the wall
- Paddle width: fits 3-4 ball widths at start

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: The twist is felt before the player can name it, and the wall clears in 2-4 minutes.

IDEA 05 OF 07

SNAKE SNACK

Eat, grow, do not bite yourself. The oldest loop still works.

THE LOOP

Guide a growing crawler around a grid eating snacks. Each snack grows you one segment and speeds you up slightly. Hit a wall or yourself and the run ends.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: TURN. Four-direction grid movement, queued so fast inputs never feel dropped.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Grid movement with input queueing
- ☐ Snack spawner that never traps the player unfairly
- ☐ Score = snacks eaten, best saved
- ☐ Wall/self collision fail state
- ☐ Eat blip that rises in pitch as you grow

CUT THIS

- ✗ Open-world movement (grid keeps it fair)
- ✗ Enemies or AI snakes
- ✗ Maze level packs
- ✗ Multiplayer

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Tick rate: start 8 moves/s, +0.25 per snack
- Grid size: 17x17 keeps runs to 2-3 minutes
- Snack spawn: never inside the snake's next 3 tiles

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: A first-time player survives 30 seconds and immediately wants one more run.

IDEA 06 OF 07

FLING SHOT

Pull back, let go, watch physics do the comedy.

THE LOOP

Drag to aim a slingshot and release to fling a projectile at stacked targets. Limited shots per round. Knock everything down to clear the round; three rounds total, then a score screen.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: FLING. Drag-aim-release is the entire interaction.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Drag-to-aim slingshot with trajectory preview
- ☐ Stacked targets with simple knock-over physics
- ☐ 3 rounds x limited shots, score per target
- ☐ Round-clear and final score screens
- ☐ Launch twang and crash thuds

CUT THIS

- ✗ More than 3 rounds
- ✗ Five projectile types (ship one, maybe two)
- ✗ Destructible terrain
- ✗ Wind/weather systems

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Shots per round: 3 (tight but fair)
- Target stacks: 4-7 blocks, stable until hit
- Trajectory dots: show ~0.8s of flight so aiming is learnable

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: The first fling makes the player laugh or gasp. If not, juice the impacts.

IDEA 07 OF 07

PATTERN RUSH

Watch the pattern. Repeat the pattern. Faster.

THE LOOP

Four colored pads flash in a sequence. Repeat it by tapping the pads in order. Each round adds one step and plays faster. One wrong tap ends the run.

THE ONE MECHANIC

One verb: REPEAT. Watch, then tap the same order.

BUILD THIS

- ☐ Four big tappable pads with flash + tone each
- ☐ Sequence grows by one step per round, tempo rises
- ☐ Round score = sequence length, best saved
- ☐ Wrong-tap fail state with instant retry
- ☐ Each pad gets its own musical pitch (free juice)

CUT THIS

- x Multiple pattern modes
- x Versus or pass-and-play
- x Unlockable pad themes
- x Long cinematic intros

TUNE IT WITH 3 NUMBERS

- Start tempo: 600ms per flash, shrink 25ms per round
- Pad size: each at least 25% of screen width (thumb-safe)
- Sequence cap: none, speed is the difficulty

WEEKEND CHECKPOINT: Reaching round 6 feels like a real achievement worth screenshotting.

You picked one. Now ship it.

An idea is worth nothing until Sunday night. The full weekend path, idea to published game to launch post, is exactly what I teach in my course:

Ship Your First Browser Game in a Weekend

A playable game live on itch.io by Sunday night.
Short video lessons. Real mistakes included. \$99.

Your next two moves

- ☐ Watch the free 90-minute build-along: I build a tiny game live, start to finish, mistakes and all.
- ☐ Join the list at chivearcade.com for the founding-member launch (\$79) the week of October 26.

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